CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

HOUSE PAINTER IN THE AI ERA

The lowest wall in the trades — no license, tiny startup cost — and a business hiding inside it for anyone who learns prep and pricing.

★ TL;DR — Median around $45K as an employee painter, enterable in 1–6 months with no license required. The catch: employee pay is the floor, not the ceiling — the money in painting lives in owning jobs, and that takes business skills, not brush skills. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

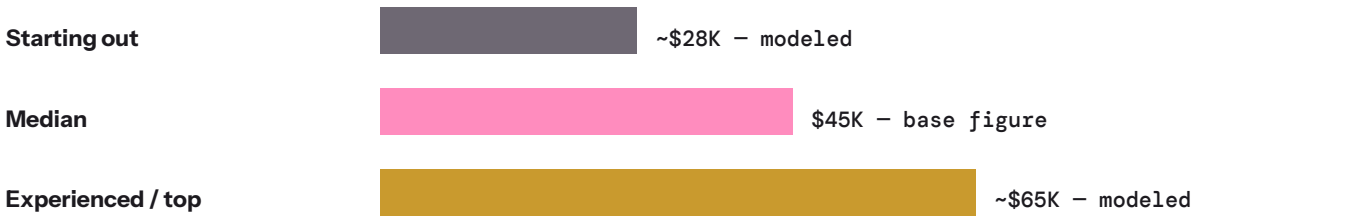
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$45K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Works because: paint is the highest-impact, lowest-cost transformation in any building, and everything painted needs repainting.
- Bites because: it's the easiest trade to enter, so low-end competition and lowball pricing are permanent weather.
- AI angle: minimal. Color-visualizer apps help sell jobs; the masking, prep, spraying and cutting-in happen on ladders, by hand.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for House Painter is a ~$45K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A HOUSE PAINTER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Prep — the real job: scrape, sand, caulk, patch, mask, and protect everything that isn't getting painted
- ✓ Apply paint by brush, roller and sprayer: walls, ceilings, trim, cabinets, exteriors
- ✓ Match colors, manage sheen and finish quality, and fix the mistakes the wall reveals
- ✓ Set up and break down sites daily: ladders, scaffolds, drop cloths, sprayers cleaned right

Think: a makeup artist for buildings — everyone sees the color; professionals know 80% of it is skin prep.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Estimating apps, color matching and virtual room painters. The robot still can't tape a straight line, float a patch, or spray a cabinet door to a factory finish.	Surface judgment: what will this wall do, what does this old coating need, where will this color actually land in this light. Plus the trust business — painters work inside people's bedrooms and businesses.

⚠ **Employee painter pay tops out quickly, and the trade's open door means you'll underbid against desperation forever at the bottom. The honest version of this career treats painting as a business apprenticeship, not a final job title.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Visible transformation daily — rooms look different because you were there ✓ Start with almost nothing: brushes, a ladder, a vehicle ✓ Interior work is climate-controlled and year-round	✗ Ladders, fumes, dust and arms overhead for hours ✗ Seasonal exteriors and weather delays ✗ Prep is tedious, invisible and absolutely non-negotiable

Good fit? You're patient, detail-eyed and steady-handed; you can spend four hours prepping a room and feel satisfied, not cheated.
Bad fit? You hate ladders and tedium, or you want employee wages to grow on their own. In painting, they don't.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PAINTER ON A COMPANY CREW	DOOR B — STRAIGHT TO YOUR OWN JOBS

Get hired by a painting company: start on prep and interiors, learn production speed, spraying and cabinet work. Six months on a good crew teaches more than any course — and you'll know exactly what a professional job looks like.	Start solo with rooms, rentals and small exteriors for your own clients. No license is generally required for painting itself — but business registration, insurance and local rules still apply. The risk: you learn pricing and quality standards the expensive way, alone.

Smart move: Learn cabinet refinishing early. It's the premium niche inside painting — kitchen cabinets pay several times room-painting rates per day, and sloppy competitors keep demand for real finishers permanent.

Where you land after: Crew painter → lead painter/foreman → your own painting company, or a specialty like cabinets and fine finishes.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
GET HIRED	MASTER THE	LEARN THE	LEARN TO	SPECIALIZE UP-MARKET	FORMALIZE THE

STEP 1 — Get hired or get a first client

FREE · WEEK 1

- Painting companies hire helpers with no experience constantly — apply, or line up two rooms for people you know.
- Either way, your real curriculum is prep: patching, sanding, caulking, masking until it's automatic.

STEP 2 — Master the basics of finish

MONTHS 1-3

- Cutting in clean lines without tape, rolling without lap marks, keeping a wet edge.
- Learn sheens and products: which paint for bathrooms, trim, cabinets, exteriors — and why.

STEP 3 — Learn the sprayer

MONTHS 2-6

- Airless spraying multiplies your speed on exteriors, new construction and cabinets.
- Masking discipline is the sprayer's tuition: overspray ruins days and reputations.

STEP 4 — Learn to estimate

ONGOING

- Time yourself honestly per room, per door, per cabinet set — your numbers become your prices.
- Watch how pros bid: labor, materials, prep condition, access. Guessing is how painters go broke busy.

STEP 5 — Specialize up-market

MONTHS 4+

- Cabinets, fine finishes, historic homes, or commercial repaints — pick the lane where quality beats price.
- Photograph before/afters of everything; paint sells visually.

STEP 6 — Formalize the business

WHEN JOBS STACK UP

- Register the business, get liability insurance, and set up simple contracts and deposits.
- Your first hire is usually a prep hand — the bottleneck you already know personally.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: apply to three painting companies or book your first two rooms.
- □ Days 1–30: prep boot camp — patch, sand, caulk, mask; cut-in practice until lines are clean.
- □ Days 31–60: production work at speed; learn sheens/products; start timing yourself per task.
- □ Days 61–90: sprayer training if on a crew; first before/after portfolio photos; write down your real per-room numbers.
- □ Day 90: working painter with evidence of finish quality — the only credential this trade respects.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ PREP IS THE PAINT JOB. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.